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To whom it may concern,

I am writing this reference letter to give my strongest recommendation for Chandrashekar Rajshekar. I first met Chandrashekar in September 2024 as teacher at the two-year bioinformatics master programme that he had enrolled. He has proved to be a highly motivated student that has always been ambitious and driven. Because of his aptitude and excellent ability to explain complex topics in computer science to his fellow students, he has been invited to teach several bioinformatics courses during his second year.

During the last year of his master studies, Chandrashekar did a course project called applied work. I acted as the supervisor of the project which focused on characterizing the differences between 64 whole-metagenome sequencing datasets collected from Arctic wetland sites in Abisko, Sweden. This was a demanding dataset to work with for several reasons, it was large in scale, ecologically complex, and requiring careful, reproducible bioinformatics practice from raw sequencing data through to comparative analysis. Chandrashekar worked independently, and was determined to understand how to run an analysis, but also to understand the details of all the bioinformatics and computational steps required to complete the analyses.

In addition, as head of the bioinformatics master's programme, I also examined his master's thesis. His performans went well beyond what I typically expect from these high achieving students. He applied and compared three machine learning models to his research questions and deployed his analyses on high-performance computing (HPC) clusters as well as in cloud containers. This combination of cutting edge bioinformatics approach and infrastructure competence reflects both technical depth and the initiative to learn tools and platforms beyond what was formally taught.

I found Chandrashekar to be intellectually curious, self-motivated, and willing to take on complex and demanding tasks. He communicates his work in a clear and logical fashion, takes feedback constructively, and holds himself to an extremely high standard. It was a pleasure to work with Chandrashekar both during teaching and in research projects.

I am confident that Ch. would bring the same ambition, rigor, and drive to a PhD position or a professional role. I recommend him without reservation and would be happy to provide further detail if it would be useful.

Sincerely,



Dag Ahrén, Associate Professor, Department of Biology, Lund University Sweden
Head of the Bioinformatics Master's Programme, Lund University, Sweden
SciLifeLab Group leader and team manager at Nationa Bioinformatics Infrastructure Sweden